20. Aurangzeb too has a mixed record and wasn't the cartoonish villain he's often made out to be. For a portrait of Aurangzeb's complexities and contradictions, see Truschke, Audrey, *Aurangzeb: The Life and Legacy of India's Most Controversial King*, Stanford University Press, 2017.
21. This was true even as Hindus too held high offices 'and were entrusted with critical state business'. Ibid.
22. Doniger, Wendy, *The Hindus: An Alternative History*, Penguin Publishing Group, 2009, p. 468.
23. Thapar, Romila, Noorani, A.G., Menon, Sadanand, *On Nationalism*, Aleph, 2016.
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25. Ibid.
26. Eaton, Richard M., *India in the Persianate Age 1000–1765*, Allen Lane, 2019, p. 392.
27. Tavernier, Jean Baptiste, (translated by Valentine Ball), *Travels in India* (1676), Macmillan and Company, 1889.
28. For a discussion of this phenomenon, see Sen, Sudipta, *Ganga: The Many Pasts of a River,* Gurgaon, Viking, 2019, p. 31.
29. Parry, Jonathan P., *Death in Banaras*, Cambridge University Press, 1994, pp. 39–40.
30. For a vivid and informative account of the Ramlila Festival of Ramnagar, see Ede, Piers Moore, *Kaleidoscope City: A Year in Varanasi*, Bloomsbury, 2015, pp. 31–50.
31. Varanasi City Census 2011 data, https://www.census2011.co.in/census/city/153-varanasi.html.
32. Mehta, Bhanu Shankar, *Unseen Banaras*, Pilgrims Publishing, 2013, p. 21.
33. '"We will never know the number of temples desecrated through India's history": Richard Eaton', Scroll.in, November 20, 2015. The only communal riot that Diana Eck mentions in *Banaras: City of Light* took place in 1809, when 'the Hindus had attempted to construct a shrine on the neutral ground between the Jnana Vapi Mosque and the Vishvanatha Temple'.